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The limitations in screen layout

Item Placement Tool allows you to redesign the windows in SAP Business One and add your own additional fields, and while this is a strong tool it is still bound to the general rules and limitations in the SAP Business One client and the SDK. This section will try to describe what can and can't be done.

Size-able windows and "inaccessible space"

Let's look at a sample. Here we have an open Sales Order where we look at the accounting tab.

The screenshot shows the SAP Sales Order window with the Accounting tab selected. Red boxes highlight several areas that are inaccessible or unusable due to the window's layout and the way it handles resizing. These areas include the top header section, the left sidebar with tabs, and the bottom status bar. The main content area is divided into several sections, some of which are also highlighted with red boxes to indicate they are not fully usable.

Without thinking I will now I've marked potential good spaces to place new content and from this point it look like we have a lot of room for a lot of additional data.

Let's think a bit more about this. Since this window is sizeable and we are not showing the screen in its minimum size our perception of a lot of room is misleading. Let's look at the same window but its minimum size.

This reveal an entire new but true image on what room we really have to work with.

Some will perhaps now remember that with the Item Placement Tool that we have the option to set a custom width and height in the configuration and that this must surely make us able to have more content. Let's again take that as a sample an give us a lot of room to work with using a size of 800 width, 700 height.

This screenshot shows the SAP Sales Order window at its minimum size. The red boxes highlight the same inaccessible areas as in the previous screenshot, but they are now much more prominent due to the smaller overall size of the window. The main content area is also significantly reduced in size, leaving very little room for additional data.

This screenshot shows the SAP Sales Order window with a large red box highlighting the main content area. This area is the most usable part of the window and is where most of the data is displayed. The red box indicates that this is the area where new content can be added, but it is also the area that is most affected by the window's resizing and layout limitations.

Now we have a lot of space that we can use but because of certain limitations how the SDK work, this additional space is in most eyes in all the incorrect places (compared to the first screen shot), and because how resizing works in SAP Business One (see below) we can end up with resize-problems here

An entire different problem away from the technical standpoint is that you should always also remember that your users might have too small screens to show your new big size of the window.

How resizing work in SAP Business One.

SAP Business One resizing of windows follow a very simple but limited set of rules. If we look at the basic window of a sales order.

This screenshot shows the SAP Sales Order window with four red boxes and arrows indicating the sections used for resizing. Section 1 is the top header, Section 2 is the left sidebar, Section 3 is the bottom status bar, and Section 4 is the main content area. The arrows show that the window is divided into four equal parts when resized, and each part moves in a specific direction (up, down, left, or right) depending on which section is being resized.

What SAP actually does while resizing is that it divides the screen in to 4 equally big portions.

- Anything within section 1 will always stay in place
- Anything within section 2 will always move right
- Anything within section 3 will always move down

• ensuring version security was always moved right and down

The screenshot shows the SAP Sales Order window with several sections highlighted by red boxes and arrows. Section 1 is the top-left area containing customer and contact information. Section 2 is the top-right area containing dates and status. Section 3 is the bottom-left area containing sales employee and remarks. Section 4 is the bottom-right area containing financial summary. A large red arrow points from Section 2 towards the right, indicating a direction of movement. The text 'Inaccessible space' is written in the center of the window, pointing to the area between the sections.

Customer: [Name], [Contact Person], [Customer Ref. No.], [Local Currency]

Section 1

Journal Remark

Payment Terms, Payment Method, Central Bank Ind.

Section 2

No. [Printer], Status [Open], Billing Date [13.01.14], Delivery Date [13.01.14], Document Date [13.01.14]

BP Project, Calculation Date, Required Date, Indicator, Federal Tax ID, Order Number

Inaccessible space

Manually Recalculate Due Date: [Months], [Days]

Cash Discount Data Entry

Sales Employee [Jürgen St.], Owner [Jürgen St.], Remarks [Add, Cancel]

Section 3

Section 4

Total Before Discount, Discount, Freight, Tax, Total

Copy From, Copy To

Some might say why can SAP Business One then resize its windows, and the answers is matrix lines.

Let's look at the Content Tab for the screenshot above.

This screenshot shows the same SAP Sales Order window but with the 'Content' tab selected. The 'Item/Service Type' table is visible, showing columns for Item No., Item Description, Quantity, Summary Type, No. of Packages, and U.. The table is empty. The same sections (1, 2, 3, 4) are highlighted with red boxes and arrows as in the previous screenshot. The text 'More room for columns and rows' is written in the center of the window, pointing to the table area.

Section 1

Section 2

Section 3

Section 4

More room for columns and rows

Here we use all the existing space for additional rows and columns which in most cases is essential.

So what can be done and what recommendations are there.

- Adding additional width to a window tend not to give resize problems so use that if you need more room but be aware that the additional room you will get will be to the right of the original content.
 - o You can of course begin to move all the original content but be aware this will be take a fairly large time.
- Use the minor spaces that we have in page 2. These are the easiest to use.
- If there are data on the existing screen that you don't use, then perhaps you can hide that and make room for your content.
- If something can't be hidden then you might be able to decrease the width or height of the data making more room for your data.
- If there is a collection of Tabs on the window that you are modifying, perhaps a good solution would be to create your own tab and put the data there.

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